Personal Statement (553 words)

On a gloomy Sunday morning in April 2021, I came home for the holidays after the second term of my first year in secondary school. Dressed in my dusty, oversized uniform, I dragged my heavy metal suitcase to our wooden gate and knocked. I salivated, picturing Mom's usual welcome-home meals: groundnuts and a special plate of colorful rice. I knocked again; nothing. I called for my elder brother. "Surely, he is home; if he isn't, someone else will hear me, then come," I said to myself. After 5 minutes, I climbed the brick fence wall. First, I marched to the kitchen hoping to see Mom, but the room was empty of both people and food. As I headed to the house, Dad suddenly came out and gave me notice of Mom's abandonment. After his words had sunk in, I remembered Mom's warnings three months prior when I had left for school: "If you take those COVID-19 vaccines, you will become a robot." She believed numerous biblical conspiracies, namely that the world was ending soon and the hidden microchips in vaccines were just the beginning. Hence, as soon as Rwanda made vaccination mandatory, she fled with my young siblings to Malawi, her home country.

Midway through the next term, the school sent me home for unpaid fees. Dad didn't ask questions. He put on his old fabric suit, marched me right back to school, and requested a scholarship. He believed in the "survival-of-the-fittest" algorithm: one has to force a victory to earn a living. So he proposed a bargain the headmaster couldn't resist: maintaining an average of 90% for the academic year or dropping out. To achieve it, I spent countless sleepless nights solving math problems and reading physics books. However, by my second year, I had constant headaches, which started affecting my performance. Although I had isolated myself from my classmates because I was ashamed of my family's situation, Darius, my seatmate, noticed my academic struggles and welcomed me to his study group, where shared explanations replaced a hundred nights of lonely struggle.

By A-level, I consistently topped the class and tutored my classmates in physics in exchange for school supplies. After winning the province-level competition with my school's robotics club, I was awarded my first laptop. Curious about how I could utilize it to earn money to help out at home, I asked my computer teacher, who recommended learning full-stack programming. Since it was not offered in our curriculum, I used my nights to master programming languages such as Python, Java, C++, and SQL using AI and YouTube as my professors. By my last year, I had built CoverSoko, a platform to compare and buy insurance policies. After publishing the repository on GitHub and recruiting collaborators from the Rwanda Coding Academy, we pitched CoverSoko at the Hanga Pitch Fest competition, Rwanda's largest startup pitching competition. After our prototype won, an investor bought it for 2,500,000 Rwandan Francs and developed it into a nationally available tool! Sometimes I look at my screen and wonder if I became the robot Mom feared, or if I am just executing Dad's survival algorithm. But seeing our

student prototype scale into a living national system proves I am not a machine. Choosing collaborators over a lonely routine was my own human upgrade to his algorithm.

Rice Supplements

Please explain what draws you to the academic areas you selected above and how you hope to explore them at Rice University. (limit: 150 words)

After winning second place at the national Hackathon with InziraAI, a career growth platform for professionals, my team was promised funding for national system integration within three months. Five months passed; nothing happened. Our code was left abandoned. While searching for other ways to scale, I pitched our models to local business directors but failed because I did not understand market traction or investor jargon. This failure proved to me that technical skills are useless without business knowledge.

Hence, I want to major in Business with a Marketing concentration to master user psychology. At Rice, I will take Design Build Ship under Professor Hesam Panahi, using his two-week sprint framework to move my tech background into real user testing. In BUSI 371: Product Development, I'll master value propositions, leveraging the Liu Idea Lab to commercialize consumer-centric ventures so my code never sits abandoned again.

Based upon your exploration of Rice University, what elements of the Rice experience appeal to you? (limit: 150 words)

When Tamara Siler visited my Bridge2Rwanda cohort, her explanation of Virani's cross-registration with the Brown School of Engineering piqued my interest. It is the best opportunity for me to master market strategy without abandoning software. Through Lilie's New Venture Challenge, I am excited to work alongside engineering peers to transform raw code into viable business models before graduation. Additionally, I will leverage opportunities such as the Center for Civic Leadership's Houston Action Research Teams to apply my technical skills to solve campus community problems and beyond. Last but not least, Houston's warm climate, similar to Rwanda's tropical climate, will allow me to train year-round with the Rice Lads on Intramural Field 3. I can already see myself bonding with my residential college housemates over post-match tactical critiques.

Option 2 (The Change Agent): Rice seeks to cultivate diverse leaders. Share a background, identity, or community that has shaped who you are, and explain how it inspires you to act as a change agent in college and beyond. (500 Words)

After winning second place in the national AI competition with InziraAI, I thought I had solved a community problem. However, our code just rusted in our GitHub repository when organizers failed to develop the project further. Even in local projects, I realized that whenever I needed coding help, I always approached students in other schools, bypassing my classmates, because they knew nothing about coding since it wasn't in our curriculum. This pattern continued after high school. Since no one else coded at my school, the systems I built—the district Seventh-day Adventist Management Information System and school attendance tracker—were going to die off because there would be no one to maintain them or fix bugs once I graduated.

So, I started teaching my classmates during prep time since they had basic computer skills. But their interests were far from technology. Refusing to give up, I campaigned for the school's first Science Club, making flyers and giving announcements during morning assemblies. 43 students enrolled. Lacking enough laptops, I approached the school for computer lab access twice a week. I encouraged students with personal laptops to share them with peers. We practiced for a whole year. My students surprised me by building the Nova Agriculture System. Through fixing bugs together late at night in the dark, we became a real family. They changed their thinking, learned to collaborate, and I gave them the maintenance keys to my school systems before leaving.

Graduating high school made me lose the family I created, but I found that I already have that personality urging me to create another one. Next, I noticed a program called Heart of Sympathy (HOS) falling behind because it lacked the technology to expand its mission of paying tuition and health insurance for poor kids. With money gained from competitions, I invested in bringing technology to this program, leading as their IT Officer.

To bring this to Houston, I will scale this exact change by acting as a physical strategic link within Rice Inno. Replicating my Science Club model, I will step into this entrepreneurship hub to bridge corporate-minded business students with technical builders who share my programming background. By sitting between commerce and code, I will teach builders how to translate raw software into viable market value propositions, ensuring their ideas survive commercial realities rather than rusting on GitHub.

Communally, I will leverage Rice's extensive research to expand my efforts with Heart of Sympathy. Within Lilie's Launchpad, I will spearhead data-driven market research to audit the financial sustainability and operational models of lagging campus civic initiatives, just as HOS was. Instead of only writing code, I will analyze consumer behaviors and manage resource allocation strategies. By securing independent undergraduate research funding through Virani, I

will study how grassroots social programs can scale using commercial toolkits. Mirroring my high school maintenance key handover, transferring these strategic business insights to local campus organizations will modernize their infrastructure, ensuring their civic impact becomes permanently self-sustaining long after we graduate.

In the expectation of receiving Mom's next award, I received her abandonment. I was coming for my second holiday in senior one, and I expected the usual cheering and energetic welcome from Mom and my siblings, plus the awards she used to give me, even with poor performance. It was during COVID, on that gloomy Sunday morning, I knocked the door, no one opened. I knocked again, nothing! For the first time, I had to find my own way in. The moment I entered, there was neither food nor people. In a minute, Dad came out of his room without even greeting me first; he gave me notice of Mom's abandonment. I was a kid of 10. With a direct kid reaction, I felt a deep ache, realizing I'd never get another award. I remembered what she said: "If you take those COVID vaccines, you will become a robot". Yet, the country had made it a must to take a vaccine before returning to school. That day meant those were her last words in my ears. Mom used to cook nice food, buy fun things for the family, and comfort me when Dad beat me to death, since she was the only family provider—Dad was broke, and angrily stayed at home. However, she enjoyed life because she thought it would end soon. She read bible books of prophecy for days and nights, and she wanted every one of us to believe in those conspiracies of hers. Dad told me she left for Malawi with all my siblings, since she's Malawian and knew there were no strict vaccine laws there like in Rwanda.

I felt like a no-parent kid, because Dad couldn't even afford school fees and materials. Yet, he still sent me back, because he believed in what he called "the survival-of-the- fittest" algorithm—working very hard for victory that earns a living. He used to relentlessly quarrel with Mom about conspiracy theories about prophecy because he was so grounded in reality. He was broke because he didn't want to do a small job; he spent days and nights calculating how to start a school. He madly beat me because of poor performance, accusing me of not using his algorithm. I used to think he was a failing hard worker, unlike my mom, who was generous but obsessed with false conspiracies. Reaching school, I was always alone, with grief and shame about what students could do if they knew I had nothing. Eventually, they sent me home because of school fees, but Dad brought me back to request a scholarship. With confidence that I could use his algorithm, he bargained a deal that the headmaster loved: "90% the whole year, or dropping out." I felt like I had to live as he wanted—through lonely, sleepless nights spent calculating math equations and physics books becoming my new family, which helped me get 90 for a while. But as a kid of 11, headaches ruined my days, and I started wondering how other students win without a death-level effort. I asked Darius, one of the intelligent students, and he explained to me how explanations in a countable group make work easier than a hundred nights of lonely struggle. Working with him academically opened other doors, as he requested more materials from his rich parents so that we could share. Darius made me realize the beauty of adopting Mom's sense of community, alongside Dad's survival-of-the-fittest algorithm—I became a kid of both at 12 years.

Those 2 personalities moved with me into A-level, where I consistently topped the class in my first year and taught physics to countless students in exchange for school materials. Teachers started believing that hard work could also be applied to extracurricular activities; at 14, they made me the school's robotics team leader. Going to our first competition, we earned our first laptops. I asked my computer teacher how it could be useful, and among his answers, he told me full-stack coding gives better jobs, but then he said it was never gonna be part of our curriculum lessons. Since I wanted survival money, I dedicated all nights to learning coding—full-stack web development, Python, Java, C++, and SQL. AI and YouTube became my professors in that full-time sleepless situation, while daytime was for typical academic work. That same laptop opened doors to hunting online opportunities, until I applied and got admitted to Isomo Academy, where I read a book about Africa's suffering—An African Elegy by Ben Okri. With coding skills I already acquired, reading motivated me to create CoverSoko, a digital platform that utilizes technology to let users compare, customize, and purchase insurance policies completely online. Pushing it on GitHub gave me collaborators from Rwanda Coding Academy. We pitched our platform to the government's Hanga Pitch Fest competition, and winning caused the entire project to be bought by an investor, Elie Tuyizere, who hired graduate engineers to scale it into a national system. That was the first time my self-taught skills addressed a real insurance problem, and earned 2,500,000 Frw from it as a team. Sometimes I look at my screens and wonder if I became the robot Mom feared, or if I am just executing Dad's survival-of-the-fittest algorithm. But then, I think CoverSoko proved I am both—using his logic to build the code, but her heart to share it with the community.

Coming for the second holiday in my first year of secondary school, I expected the usual cheering welcome from Mom and siblings, plus awards she gave me even with poor performance. On a gloomy Sunday during COVID, I knocked the door—no one opened. I knocked again, nothing! First time, I had to find my own way in. Entering, there was neither food nor people. Dad came out without greeting me; he gave notice of Mom's abandonment. I was 10. I felt a child's deep ache, realizing I'd never get another award. I was expecting the usual cheering welcome from Mom and my siblings, plus the awards she gave me despite my poor performance. In expectation of receiving Mom's next award, I received her abandonment.

I remembered her words: "If you take those COVID vaccines, you will become a robot." Yet, vaccination was mandatory for returning to school; that day meant those were her last words in my ears. Despite her love, Mom believed the world would soon end. She read biblical prophecy books day and night, wanting everyone to believe her conspiracies. Dad told me she left for Malawi with my siblings since she's Malawian and knew there were no strict vaccine laws like in Rwanda.

When sent home for fees the next term, I felt like a no-parent kid because Dad couldn't afford school fees and materials. He was broke, refusing small jobs, spending nights calculating how to start a school. Dad brought me back to request a scholarship. Confident in his "survival-of-the-fittest" algorithm—working hard for a victory and living- he bargained a deal the headmaster loved: "90% the whole year, or dropping out."

Back in school, I felt alone and ashamed of having nothing. So, I lived as he wanted: spending sleepless nights doing math and reading physics books to maintain that average grade.

By A-level, I consistently topped my class and taught physics to countless students in exchange for school materials. Teachers began seeing how my work ethic could extend beyond academics; hence, in my fourth year, I became the school's robotics team leader. At our first competition, I earned my first laptop. I asked my computer teacher how I could better utilize it to earn money, and he recommended learning full-stack coding, but it wasn't taught at my school. Since I needed money for survival, I dedicated countless nights to learning multiple tools for full-stack development: Python, Java, C++, and SQL. With my eagerness to earn through

coding, I created CoverSoko, a digital platform that lets users compare, customize, and purchase insurance policies entirely online. Pushing it on GitHub connected me with Rwanda Coding Academy students, who helped me develop its database further. We pitched CoverSoko at the government's Hanga Pitch Fest business competition, where our winning project was bought and scaled into a national system. That was the first time my self-taught skills addressed a real insurance problem, and earned 2,500,000 Frw from it as a team. Sometimes I look at my screens and wonder if I became the robot Mom feared, or if I am just executing Dad's survival-of-the-fittest algorithm. But then, I think CoverSoko proved I am both—using his logic to build the code, but her heart to share it with the community.

Disregarded sentences:

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AI and YouTube became my professors in that full-time sleepless situation, while daytime was for typical academic work.

Those personalities followed me into A-level, where

On a gloomy Sunday in April 2021, I returned home for the holidays after the second term of my first year in boarding school. Dressed in a dusty school uniform that did not fit my short body, I dragged a heavy metal case packed with books and laundry. I expected the usual cheering welcome and tight hugs from Mom and my siblings, plus the rewards she always gave me even when I brought home continuous poor academic performances. She used to comfort me by buying a big five-hundred-franc box of prepared groundnuts or cooking a special plate of colorful, spiced rice. I knocked on our wooden gate, but no one opened. I knocked again, nothing! Because I couldn't open the lock while balancing my heavy metal case, I struggled, scrambled over the brick fence wall, and dropped inside. The kitchen door was wide open, but there was neither cooked nor uncooked food left on the shelves. In that confusion, wandering around for what felt like twenty minutes, I noticed the house was completely silent with no signs of life. Suddenly, Dad came out of his room without even greeting me and gave me the notice of Mom's abandonment. I was ten. I wept on the floor as a deep ache took over, realizing I would never get another box of groundnuts or a special rice award. I remembered her warning: "If you take those COVID-19 vaccines, you will become a robot." She spent days and nights reading biblical prophecy books like Daniel and Revelation, forcing everyone in our neighborhood to join her prayer circles to escape the beast and its microchips. Because Rwanda made vaccines mandatory to return to school, she fled to Malawi with my young siblings where laws were flexible.

Reaching school the next term, I carried the deep shame of having nothing, constantly terrified of judgment from classmates. Dad was broke, refusing small jobs because he spent nights calculating how to start a school, and he violently beat me for my continuous poor performance, accusing me of neglecting his algorithm. In the middle of the third term, the school sent me home for unpaid fees. Dad didn't ask questions; he just went into his room, dressed in an old fabric suit Mom had bought him, and marched me right back to the administration building. He spent our last cash on the one-thousand-franc transport fare for us both. Sitting in the office, the headmaster sat back in his large stretching chair, adjusted his black suit, and laughed out loud when Dad requested a scholarship for me to study for free. But confident in his "survival-of-the-fittest" algorithm, which meant forcing a victory to earn a living, Dad bargained a high-stakes deal that the headmaster finally accepted: "90% the whole year, or dropping out." Back in class, I lived exactly as he wanted. I spent lonely, sleepless nights: completing complex math problems and reading heavy physics books to maintain that 90% average grade. By my second year, constant headaches ruined my days. Wondering how others achieved academic success without death-level effort, I approached an intelligent classmate, Darius. He welcomed me into his physics study group, showing me how shared explanations in a countable group replace a hundred nights of lonely struggle. We shared materials his rich parents bought, teaching me the beauty of adopting Mom's collaborative heart alongside Dad's survival algorithm. I became a kid of both at twelve.

Those two personalities followed me into A-level, where I consistently topped the class and taught physics to students for school supplies. Teachers saw my work ethic, and I became the school's robotics team leader in my fourth year. Winning our first competition earned me a first laptop. I asked my computer science teacher, Martin Hatanga, how to utilize it to earn survival money. He recommended full-stack coding, which was entirely outside our school curriculum. I built a strict personal routine, keeping my daytime for normal school lessons and dedicating my nights to mastering programming tools like Python, Java, C++, and SQL using AI and YouTube as professors. Wanting to address real-world challenges, I built CoverSoko, a digital platform that lets users compare, customize, and purchase insurance policies completely online. I published the repository on GitHub and shared the link on my personal network to recruit talented student collaborators from Rwanda Coding Academy. Together, we spent weeks redesigning the database structure. We pitched CoverSoko at the government's Hanga Pitch Fest competition. Our prototype won the challenge, and an investor bought the platform to scale it into a national system within government infrastructure, earning 2,500,000 Frw for our team. Sometimes I look at my screens and wonder if I became the robot Mom feared, or if I am executing Dad's survival algorithm. But CoverSoko proved I am both, using his calculation logic to build code, but her collaborative heart to serve our community.

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Common App Prompt: 1. Some students have a background, identity, interest, or talent that is so meaningful they believe their application would be incomplete without it. If this sounds like you, then please share your story.

At home, we were born four, and personally, I always saw something solid in being the second-born. Actually, what I found interesting about it was that it gave me a quiet vantage point right in the middle. The lastborns always brought these loud, crazy vibes to the house, and the spotlight was always on Bless because he was the firstborn. But being in the middle meant I could just sit back and silently observe how our family worked. It was a system with two completely different parts. On one side was Mama Bless, my Malawian mother, who was basically the human side of the home. She earned the money, brought in decorations, and always wanted to make our house a beautiful, warm family space. She was so generous that she would even give us awards when we brought home poor academic performance. But then, she messed up because she wasn't a hard worker, and she was not grounded in reality at all. She was completely ruined by abstract conspiracies of prophecy. Mama Bless was always teaching us how the world is going to end, claiming that it's what Adventist books tell, and she never believed she had to work hard since she thought we had a few days on the earth—Revelation's cloud Prophecy. On the other side was Papa Bless, my Rwandan father, who was completely grounded in reality. He thought big, loved calculations, and was super serious. But then, he was just a failed hard worker. He was always broke because he refused to do small jobs, always thinking of making something giant, and he loved punishing us hard. Hey, I am not saying the use of a stick. He always used whatever object was close to him, and I can remember countless household materials he destroyed just for beating us. So I grew up with these weird east and west ropes hanging in front of me, and I was stuck in the middle, trying to figure out which side to pull.

But then, everything completely broke in 2020 when COVID-19 emerged along with its vaccines. Mama Bless had this deep belief from her prophecies that taking the vaccine meant adopting microchips in the body, which she defined as surrendering your control to robots. Before I went to school for the second term, she looked at me and said, "If you take those vaccines, you will become a robot." Those were her last words to me. Yeah, her exact last words. At the moment, I didn't know what the robot even was, and I felt the urge of wanting to know about it, but my Papa didn't allow me to ask. When I came home for the holidays after term two, I walked up to the door and found a silence that didn't make any sense at all. I knocked on the door, but no one opened it. I knocked again; nothing. For the first time in my life, I had to learn how to open a door with no help. I entered, and the house was a total ghost town. There was no food, no decorations, and my two youngest siblings were completely gone. I was a kid of ten. A kid of ten in senior one, standing in a completely empty house. It felt like I was in a dark tunnel, and not close to any of its ending. Our house was near a forest, and I felt zero peace at all. At first, I was so mad at her. I kept asking myself why she would even leave me behind. If she really

believed a giant tragedy was coming to reach our family, and she wanted to save her children, then why would she leave Bless and me there to face it? It didn't make sense. Did she just love her country and her parents in Malawi more than us? But then, as a kid, your mind can't fully process those things, so I just stayed with this heavy, painful question in my heart.

The transition after she left was a complete nightmare. I can vividly remember the silence of my brother Bless in the house. He used to be super stubborn and full of vibes, but he became deeply depressed. We agreed to divide the home activities in such a way that I would do the mopping and he would wash the clothes, but then he would directly forget what we agreed on in just a few minutes. It was like depression was bringing him something like ADHD, and it was so hard to live in that environment. When I went to school, I was in a total dilemma. I didn't want to go into any discussion that talked about parents at all. My friend Darius would always ask me why I didn't want to story-tell anymore, but I just couldn't say anything. I was a kid, and I was secretly dreaming of how I could connect with Mama Bless so that she could also take me with her. I was so close to the younger siblings she took, but I wasn't close to my father at all, and I couldn't imagine how this harsh, punishing father was the person I was going to spend the rest of my time with. I couldn't imagine going to school to work hard without my mom's rewards for the previous work, and at the same time, we had no materials, no school fees, and nothing. Papa Bless didn't comfort us; he just continued being harsh and started telling us that a man uses the survival-of-the-fittest algorithm to survive and keep existing. I spent the first month of term three in senior one doing absolutely nothing. I just hung there, completely paralyzed by the dilemma of whether I should work hard or just focus on finding a way to connect with my mom. The headmaster eventually pissed me off because I wasn't paying fees and I wasn't working in the school. It was basically like I was dropping out, just like Bless eventually did because his performance suffered and the teachers wouldn't tolerate it anymore.

But then, my dad, who was completely grounded in reality and believed every person must work to exist, marched me back to school to ask the headmaster if I could study for free. The headmaster laughed out loud at a broke father's confidence, but Papa Bless had this crazy confidence that didn't flinch. He made a deal: I had to get a ninety by the end of every term, or I would drop out. That was the moment I started grounding myself into books, because as a kid, I took it as a formula that every person should learn to avoid dropping out. But then, I had no school materials at all. This is where the characteristics of both my parents started mixing inside me to save my life. To get materials, I had to use my father's hard work to master the topics, but then I also had to adopt my mother's friendly, human side to connect with people. I started approaching my classmates, talking to them, and explaining difficult lessons to them so that they would share their scarce school materials with me. It was a literal survival-of-the-fittest algorithm. With that said, I still hid my family life from them. Whenever they asked about my home, I would quickly change topics or ask questions about their own families so they wouldn't ask about mine. But Darius noticed I was hiding things, and we actually broke up from being friends because I didn't have the words to explain what caused me to change. At some point,

humility grew inside me. I realized I couldn't survive alone, so I approached Darius and told him the entire truth about my home. I can't believe what happened next—he told his rich parents, and they literally doubled his materials so that I could teach him and we could share everything as friends. I survived that year because I used my father's logic to study and my mother's humanity to build a connection. I needed both sides.

I carried this exact same balance into A'Level. I worked relentlessly and became the valedictorian, and that intense academic hard work planted a deep trust in my teachers. They saw my drive and gave me the role of robotics team leader in senior four. We went to the National competition, took fourth place, and that is how I got my first new life-laptop. When I told Souvenir—my cousin, who was admitted to Rwanda Coding Academy, a top Rwandan school that provides all the tech materials students need to become nationwide developers—that I finally owned a laptop, he told me that was all I needed to get the skills to earn money and survive. At that point, I desperately wanted money. I wanted to buy my own needs and take care of my brother Bless, who had dropped out. So I started exploring every single computer-related thing online that could make money. I discovered coding from a guy on YouTube, and my teacher told me there is real money in full-stack programming, but he said it was not a part of our curriculum at all. So this kid of fourteen decided to design a crazy schedule: daytime for normal advanced physics academics, and nighttime for coding. AI and YouTube became my coding professors, and I was completely sleepless. But then, coding became my ultimate therapy because of the instant gratification of solving a bug. My home life had been a chaotic mess that I couldn't fix, but on the screen, if there was an error, I could use logic to fix it completely.

Searching for information online became a routine. On the night of exploring the further I could go, I saw the Isomo application. The laptop opened the door to Isomo Academy, and during the December challenge, they urged us to solve a community problem. That is when I developed SHAKISHA, a web application where people can post lost items. And this is exactly where the theme of choices and my parents comes together. The hard work to sit down and code the full-stack app came straight from my father's grounded reality, but the reason I built it—to care for the local community—came straight from my mother's generosity. But then, building SHAKISHA taught me that trying to do everything alone was completely overwhelming and impossible. If I wanted to address big community questions, coding had to be a collaborative execution. So, early this year, I started teaching full-stack programming in our robotics club. I didn't do it to trade tutoring for books anymore; I did it because I wanted my peers to also have the skills for collaborative coding. I wanted to serve them and build a family-ish team beside me. That experience completely changed my understanding of life. I realized that a person doesn't have to use a lonely, selfish survival-of-the-fittest algorithm to exist. Basically, what I am saying is that a man is someone who earns by using his skills to solve community problems, even at the financial risk of losing all those earnings.

If I look at where I am standing right now, I am completely a product of both of them. Bless founded a small-scale business since he couldn't finish school, and sometimes I honestly feel like I am living for him because he didn't get the opportunities I got. Papa is so proud of me now, and he always claims that I achieved all of this because he put me in a hard-working situation. But then, Papa doesn't know that it was my Mama Bless side—the human connection, the humility to approach Darius, and the love for community—that actually kept me alive. With that said, I still don't talk to Mama Bless at all. Her ideas were ruined, and I still don't know why she left me alone in that silence. Sometimes I look at my computer screens and wonder about the things she told me about robots. Am I a robot now because I spend my life coding? I don't know. And honestly, she still owes me my awards for all these years of hard work. But then, I still have her side inside me. When I am with my friends, I love feeling family-ish. I love to talk long with them, wear the same clothes, and buy the exact same bracelets. I hold onto that warmth, but then I also hold onto my father's hard work to find real solutions. I don't want to walk through doors alone anymore. I want to be in an environment of coders and diverse thinkers who will challenge me to completely rewrite the survival-of-the-fittest algorithm from a lonely fight into a collaborative service.

1. **Please explain what draws you to the academic areas you selected above and how you hope to explore them at Rice University. (150 words)**

After winning second place at the national Hackathon with InziraAI, a career growth platform for professionals, my team was promised funding for national system integration within three months. Five months passed; nothing happened. Our code was left abandoned. While searching for other ways to scale, I pitched our models to local business directors but failed because I did not understand market traction or investor jargon. This failure proved to me that technical skills are useless without business knowledge.

Hence, I want to major in Business with a Marketing concentration to master user psychology. At Rice, I will take Design Build Ship under Professor Hesam Panahi, using his two-week sprint framework to move my tech background into real user testing. In BUSI 371: Product Development, I'll master value propositions, leveraging the Liu Idea Lab to commercialize consumer-centric ventures so my code never sits abandoned again.

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2. **Based upon your exploration of Rice University, what elements of the Rice experience appeal to you? (150 words) ?**

When Tamara Siler visited my Bridge2Rwanda cohort, her explanation of Virani's cross-registration with the Brown School of Engineering piqued my interest. It is the best opportunity for me to master market strategy without abandoning software. Through Lilie's New Venture Challenge, I am excited to work alongside engineering peers to transform raw code into viable business models before graduation. Additionally, I will leverage opportunities such as the Center for Civic Leadership's Houston Action Research Teams to apply my technical skills to solve problems in the campus community and beyond. Last but not least, Houston's warm climate, similar to Rwanda's tropical climate, will allow me to train year-round with the Rice Lads on Intramural Field 3. I can already see myself bonding with my residential college housemates over post-match tactical critiques.

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3. **Residential college question**

    a. **Option 2 (The Change Agent):** Rice seeks to cultivate diverse leaders. Share a background, identity, or community that has shaped who you are, and explain how it inspires you to act as a change agent in college and beyond. ✅ (500 Words)

After winning second place in the national AI competition with InziraAI, I mistakenly believed that engineering a complex codebase was the ultimate metric of human progress. However, when organizers failed to develop the project further, our code simply sat rusting in our GitHub

repository. This absolute stagnation forced me to look closely at my immediate community. I realized that whenever I encountered severe programming roadblocks, I automatically bypassed my own classmates, who knew nothing about development because coding was entirely absent from our school curriculum, to seek collaboration from students in external schools. This unsustainable pattern meant that the structural systems I had independently deployed, including the district Seventh-day Adventist Management Information System and our school attendance tracker, were bound to rot the moment I graduated because no local infrastructure existed to maintain them.

My identity shifted permanently when I stopped looking for isolated answers and decided to build that missing infrastructure myself. I launched an aggressive campaign for the school's first Science Club, designing flyers and delivering morning assembly pitches to enroll forty-three students. When a lack of computers threatened our momentum, I negotiated laboratory access with school administrators and coordinated a peer-led laptop-sharing program.

This community completely rearchitected who I am. Managing an ecosystem of peers with vastly different initial interests taught me that leadership is not the act of being the smartest technician in the room; it is the art of coordinating human potential and distributing ownership. My students fundamentally proved this to me when they unexpectedly engineered the Nova Agriculture System code to automate seed spacing and calculate depth. Even though they lacked the embedded hardware components to build the physical device, their raw initiative showed me that true transformation happens when you empower others to become independent problem-solvers. I was no longer just a lonely coder; I became a community architect. Before leaving, I handed the master maintenance keys of my district systems to five student mentors, trusting the ecosystem I had grown.

Graduating made me realize that this cooperative mindset had become my permanent personal compass. Post-graduation, when I noticed the Heart of Sympathy (HOS) program falling behind because it lacked the digital tracking platforms to scale its mission of funding tuition and healthcare for vulnerable children, I did not just see a software deficit. I saw a community needing a strategic framework. I deployed my personal competition earnings to fund their technological transition, leading as their IT Officer to optimize their resource distribution systems.

Beyond high school, this philosophy defines how I will act as a change agent in college and throughout my career. I will enter my undergraduate community determined to break the invisible walls that isolate technical builders from organizational strategists. By establishing cross-disciplinary innovation ecosystems wherever I go, I will mobilize diverse teams to audit operational bottlenecks and scale grassroots initiatives. True change is not an individual sprint. My education will be weaponized to turn knowledge into a transferable asset, leaving every community I enter permanently more capable of architecting its own future.

1. **Please describe the challenges or circumstances and how they have impacted you. (Min: 1 / Max: 250)**

In O-level, I owned no soap, lotion, toothpaste, or toilet paper. Yet classmates in Darius's physics group turned to me when difficult concepts confused them. We were friends, not customers. We cleaned our dormitory together, shared toothpaste, and divided toilet paper sheet by sheet. I learned I could lack what others needed to live comfortably and still be someone they relied on to understand physics.

During A-level holidays, without electricity at home, I walked four kilometers to Kabarondo sector office to code and download time-dilation modules through free Wi-Fi. I sat on red back stairs beneath a torn roof, sometimes working in the rain. When our water ran out, Blessing and I carried yellow jerrycans to River Rugazi, then washed clothes and prepared the cassava and sweet potatoes Dad could afford. My days moved between finding water for our household and finding internet for my curiosity. Neither could wait for easier circumstances.

When our mother took my younger siblings to Malawi, Blessing dropped out, lonely and forgetful, while I was struggling to remain in school myself. Still, I gave him 300,000 Frw from CoverSoko's prize money for necessities. He carried builders' supplies before opening a small grocery shop. When business slows, I send him part of my winnings; those same prizes, alongside Dad, help pay my A-level fees.

My mother and I have not spoken since. She sends no support, and I cannot change that. I can decide to stay: when a prize arrives, part of it goes to Blessing.

2. **Please provide any additional information you wish to share. (Min: 1 / Max: 300)**

I joined the A-level robotics club uninterested in icebreakers; I came from hardship wanting only to build. My deep voice overruled me. The circle handed me the middle to lead Kabuti, a game: when I called "turn," everyone turned; when I called "Kabuti," they kept circling, and whoever faced the wrong way was out. Ms. Fillette, my physics teacher, opened every Wednesday lesson with an icebreaker and called me forward, because a deep voice makes the game less boring. I discovered I could change a room's mood on purpose. People meet me and look up, expecting someone taller. I say my voice is the production build; the rest of me is still in development.

I use voice and humor on heavy weeks. During application season, when friends groaned about 250-word limits, I read their drafts aloud in my deepest movie-trailer voice: "In a world with only 250 words, one student dared to write 251." They laughed, then deleted the extra word, lighter than before. Fun eases the pressure. I joke about myself too: my voice has a full-time job; my height works part-time. When exhaustion arrives, I beatbox it with a bass-heavy soundtrack, my talent at Friday bonfires.

Humor lightens a room; arrangement is how I build one. Owning little taught me that everything needs a place: soap beside the shared toothpaste, clothes folded, nothing loose. At home, nobody mopped for me, so I mopped, then checked corners for anything forgotten. Now I cannot leave a room until every object has its place, and I usually notice what went missing.

My portfolio, ayamikani.vercel.app, holds the rest. Start with the Gallery: friends, family, and teams laughing beside things we built. Projects such as CoverSoko, the parking management system, and the EUCL token tool include full descriptions; Certificates list my qualifications. Explore freely.

If you would like to upload a resume, you may do so now or at a later time.

1. Resume

The Rice Box: In keeping with Rice's long-standing tradition, please share an image of something that appeals to you.

2. Image

New additional Activities.

1. Intare Football Club — Starting Left Winger (Number 11)

- **Activity type:** Sports: Varsity
- **Position:** Starting Left Winger (Number 11)
- **Organization:** Intare FC (Nyagatare District)
- **Grades:** 11, 12, Post-Graduate
- **When:** During school year and holidays
- **Participation:** Jan 2025 – Present
- **Hours/week:** 8
- **Weeks/year:** 12
- **Description:** Competed as starting winger in Rwanda National U-17 Division 1; spearheaded district squad to 4th place finish in rigorous inter-district tournament.

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2. Indindamakuza — Lead Male Traditional Dancer & Cultural Ambassador

- **Activity type:** Dance
- **Position:** Lead Male Traditional Dancer & Cultural Ambassador
- **Organization:** Indindamakuza Cultural Troupe
- **Grades:** 11, 12, Post-Graduate
- **When:** During school year and holidays
- **Participation:** Jul 2025 – Present
- **Hours/week:** 4
- **Weeks/year:** 10

- **Description:** Perform traditional choreography for state ministers and international delegates; preserve Rwandan heritage; orchestrate boot camp cultural exhibitions.

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1. Isomo Academy — Music & Drums MySpace Performer

- **Activity type:** Arts: Performing
- **Position:** Beatboxer & Vocal Percussion Artist
- **Organization:** Isomo Academy MySpace Program
- **Grades:** 11, 12, Post-Graduate
- **When:** During school year and holidays
- **Participation:** Jul 2024 – Present
- **Hours/week:** 3
- **Weeks/year:** 8
- **Description:** Developed beatboxing artistry within intensive creative modules; showcased vocal tracks and layered acoustic textures across multiple regional talent events.

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2. SDA Church — DJ - Sound Controller & Bass Choir Leader

- **Activity type:** Religious
- **Position:** Sound Controller, DJ & Bass Choir Leader
- **Organization:** Nyagatare Secondary Seventh-day Adventist Church
- **Grades:** 11, 12
- **When:** During the school year
- **Participation:** Jan 2025 – Aug 2026
- **Hours/week:** 5
- **Weeks/year:** 35
- **Description:** Directed live audio tracking every Saturday morning; engineered microphone balance while conducting the baseline sections for our regional men's choir.

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9. Isomo December Challenge

Activity type: Community Service (Volunteer)
Position: Communications Lead
Organization: Isomo Academy
Grades: 10, 11
When: During school break
Participation: 2024, 2025

Description: Led communications for a 3-person team across 2 challenges; supported 20+ people at Gahini Hospital and a family of 12 using 110K RWF.